

W H A L E C L A S S

Circle Time Guide

Everything you need, one page per day

Autumn (2)

Week 8

Week of Oct 12–16

13 minutes a day

ages 2.5–6

English learners





Week 8 · Week Overview

Autumn (2)

Print · laminate · ring-bind · hold this all week

5 words they'll own by Friday →

tree

fall

cold

harvest

climb

Littles (2.5–3)

One word + a gesture is a win: **"Fall!"** (one hand drops from high to the floor), **"Cold!"** (hug yourself and shiver, brrr), **"Climb!"** (both hands pulling up a ladder).

Bigs (4–6)

Sentence frames:

"The leaves fall from the tree."

"It is cold in autumn."

"We climb up high."

"I can ____!"

The week at a glance

MON	Tree · One by One	two twigs for the Magic Box
TUE	Fall · Down They Come	a basket of fallen leaves in the Magic Box
WED	Cold · Brrr! Dress Warm	a scarf, a woolly hat and one glove in the Magic Box (leave the box by an open window for ten...
THU	Harvest · The Autumn Basket	the harvest basket in the Magic Box
FRI	Climb climbing high + Big Review	Double Ninth cake (or any steamed cake) wrapped up, a chrysanthemum and a walking stick; every prop from...

2 MIN

Magic Box hook

4 MIN

Teach the words

3 MIN

Song · today's verse

3 MIN

Game · move it

1 MIN

Whisper-shout close

Weekly rituals — use these every single day

Attention grabber: Teacher: **"One, two, three — eyes on me!"** · Kids: **"One, two — eyes on you!"**

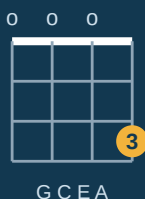
The Magic Box: any box with a lid. Chant it, shake it, sniff it, peek dramatically — the day's key prop lives inside.

The two-tier rule: never make a little produce a sentence, and never let a big get away with one word.

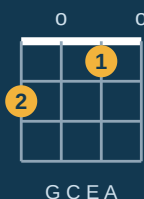
Whisper → shout close: calms them down, then releases them — every single closing.

Teacher-fails-on-purpose: once a day, get it wrong and let them correct you — the correction shout is the loudest language of the day.

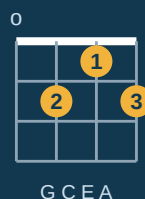
One song a week: same chorus at every circle, one new verse each morning, the whole song on Friday.



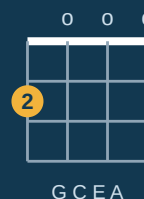
C



F



G7



Am

Uke quick-ref

Strum: Down · Down · Down-Up ("leaves — come — down-a"). Can't manage it yet? Four slow downs per bar works fine — the kids only hear the fun.

The song needs only **C · F · G7 · Am**.

MONDAY

Tree · One by One

Grab: two twigs for the Magic Box — one completely **bare**, one still **leafy**; the tree character card; a space to stand up in.

2 MIN MAGIC BOX HOOK

The box is light today, and it rattles like dry sticks. Whole class chants:

EVERYONE "What's in the box? What's in the box?"

Shake it — *tick, tick, tick*. Sniff it. Peek in and frown, puzzled.

TEACHER "Two sticks. Just... two sticks?" (*lift both twigs out together, one in each hand, and hold them high*)

Wait. Let them see it themselves: one hand is **full**, one hand is **empty**.

Arms up like branches. **"Tree!"**

4 MIN TEACH · TREE

Both twigs go round the circle, one child at a time — hold the leafy one in one hand and the bare one in the other, and feel the difference.

A tall, tall **tree**... (*stand up, arms wide and high*)

Leaves on every branch! (*wiggle all ten fingers up high*)

One... lets go. (*one finger flutters down*)

And one... and one... (*two more*)

Now the tree is **BARE**. (*arms up, every finger still*)

LITTLES say the one word and put their arms up: **"Tree!"** **BIGS** take the frame: **"The leaves fall from the tree."**

Then take them to the window. Which tree outside is **finished**? Which one is still going? Nobody has to be right — they only have to look.

Teacher fails: hold up the **bare** twig and admire it. "Ohhh... look at ALL these beautiful leaves." Start counting them, seriously. Wait for the roar.

Lay the **tree** card beside the two twigs on the mat. Say it once, in Chinese, and leave it there — one character a day, no drilling.

3 MIN GAME · TREE, TREE, BARE TREE

"One, two, three — eyes on me!" Everybody stands up and becomes a tree: arms up as branches, ten fingers spread as leaves.

TEACHER "The wind is coming..." (*one slow clap*)

On every clap, **one finger folds away**. Count them down out loud together — ten, nine, eight... The last clap drops both arms to your sides.

"Bare!" **BIGS** **"The tree is bare."**

Play it twice: once slow and sad, once fast and silly. Then let a child be the wind and do the clapping.

Going down from ten is a real counting exercise hiding inside a game. Say the numbers **with** them, never at them — the Littles join in around six.

1 MIN CLOSE

Arms up like branches, then everything drops on the shout. Whisper → normal → shout:

EVERYONE "Fall... cold... CLIMB! Happy AUTUMN!" (*flutter down · shiver · hands pull up a ladder · both arms fly open*)

Got 3 spare minutes? *Leaf Man* (Lois Ehlert) — every picture is made of real leaves. Stop on each page and ask what it turned into.

♪ **TODAY'S SONG MOMENT · DOWN, DOWN, DOWN THE LEAVES COME** chorus → Monday's verse → chorus

CHORUS

C Down, down, down the **F** leaves come **C** down, (*both hands flutter to the floor*)

F The tree is bare and the **C** field is **G7** brown! **C** (*arms up bare, then sweep low*)

Am Cold on my nose and **F** cold on my **C** toes, (*touch nose, touch toes*)

F That's how the **C** autumn **G7** goes! **C** (*big shrug, both hands out*)

MONDAY · TREE

C A tall, tall tree with a hundred leaves, (*arms up, fingers wiggling*)

G7 One by one — **C** the autumn takes! (*fingers fold away one at a time*)

The one song of the week — same chorus at every circle, one new verse each morning. Chords and the full sheet are on the Song tab. The chorus is a finger-play: they will do the actions long before they sing the words.

TUESDAY

Fall · Down They Come

Today's words: **fall** (*tree comes back every day*)

Grab: a **basket of fallen leaves** in the Magic Box — as many as you can gather on the way in, dry ones; the autumn card; floor space for twenty children to spin and land.

2 MIN MAGIC BOX HOOK

The box is fat today, and it **rustles**. Chant it, then hold it up over your head.

EVERYONE "What's in the box? What's in the box?"

Shake it — a huge dry rustle. Sniff it — it smells of outside.

TEACHER "Ready? Look UP..." (*tip the whole basket out from as high as you can reach*)

Leaves land on every head. Let the shrieking run for five whole seconds before you say anything.

One hand drops from high to the floor. "**Fall!**"

4 MIN TEACH · FALL

Everyone picks up **one** leaf and holds it up as high as their arm goes.

Up on the branch... (*arm high, hand still*)

Hold on... hold on... (*everyone frozen*)

Let... **go**. (*fingers open*)

Fall, fall, fall... (*watch it all the way down, nobody moves*)

DOWN! (*flat hand on the floor when it lands*)

Do it three times. The waiting is the lesson — twenty children watching one leaf come down is the quietest the room will be all week.

LITTLES say the one word and drop a hand: "**Fall!**" **BIGS** "**The leaf falls from the tree.**"

Teacher fails: throw your leaf **up** and announce brightly, "Look! It's **falling!**" while it is clearly going up. Nod, satisfied. Wait for them to fix you.

The **autumn** card goes down beside yesterday's tree. Autumn is the season that takes the leaves off — say it once, in Chinese, and move on.

3 MIN GAME · LEAF CATCH

"One, two, three — eyes on me!" Everyone gathers a small handful of leaves and stands in a circle, well spread out.

TEACHER "Throw them UP... and catch ONE before it lands!" (*throw your own handful straight up*)

Almost nobody catches one the first time. That is the joke and they love it. "**Fall!**" **BIGS** "**I caught one leaf!**"

Three rounds. Then the quiet version: throw them up and **don't** catch — freeze, and watch every single one land. Count how long the last one takes.

Finish by sweeping them all back into the basket together, everybody, no exceptions. The tidy-up is part of the game — announce it that way and it stays fun.

1 MIN CLOSE

Both hands high, fluttering down as the voice comes up. Whisper → normal → shout:

EVERYONE "Fall... cold... CLIMB! Happy AUTUMN!" (*flutter down · shiver · hands pull up a ladder · both arms fly open*)

Got 3 spare minutes? *Fletcher and the Falling Leaves* (Julia Rawlinson) — a little fox worries about his tree losing every leaf. Stop before the last page and ask what they think happens.

♪ **TODAY'S SONG MOMENT · DOWN, DOWN, DOWN THE LEAVES COME** chorus → Tuesday's verse → chorus

CHORUS

C Down, down, down the **F** leaves come **C** down, (*both hands flutter to the floor*)

F The tree is bare and the **C** field is **G7** brown! **C** (*arms up bare, then sweep low*)

Am Cold on my nose and **F** cold on my **C** toes, (*touch nose, touch toes*)

F That's how the **C** autumn **G7** goes! **C** (*big shrug, both hands out*)

TUESDAY · FALL

C Fall, leaf, fall — spin and sway, (*turn slowly, arms loose*)

G7 Down to the ground **C** you go today! (*sink to the floor and go still*)

Sing this one *standing*. Everybody is a leaf; the last word puts them on the floor. It is the easiest transition to sitting you will ever get.

WEDNESDAY

Cold · Brrr! Dress Warm

Today's words: **cold** (*tree · fall come back*)

Grab: a scarf, a woolly hat and one glove in the Magic Box (leave the box by an open window for ten minutes first so it is genuinely cold to touch); a sun hat and a pair of sandals for the sort; the two sorting signs (print pack pages 12–13); the cold card.

2 MIN MAGIC BOX HOOK

Before the chant, the box goes round the circle and **everybody puts one hand flat on it**. Say nothing. Watch the faces.

EVERYONE "What's in the box? What's in the box?"

TEACHER "Ooh... the box is **cold**." (*shiver from head to toe, hug yourself, teeth chattering*)

Peek in, then pull the scarf out slowly and wind it round your neck, twice, with a huge sigh of relief.

Everyone hugs themselves and shivers. "**Cold!**"

4 MIN TEACH · COLD

Hat, scarf, glove — each one goes on you, in the wrong order, while they watch.

Cold on my nose! (*touch your nose, shiver*)

Cold on my toes! (*touch your toes*)

Hat... scarf... glove... (*mime each one going on*)

Now I am **WARM!** (*big hug of yourself, whole body relaxes*)

LITTLES shiver and say the one word: "**Cold!**" **BIGS** take the frame: "**It is cold in autumn.**" and "**I wear a hat.**"

Then out to the window or the door: everybody touches the railing or the glass with one finger. **is it cool?** Come back in and touch a friend's warm hand. Cold, warm, cold, warm.

Teacher fails: put the woolly hat carefully on your **foot**. Sit back, pleased. "Ahh. That's better now, isn't it?" Wait for twenty children to move it for you.

The **cold** card joins tree and autumn on the shelf edge. Three down, two to go.

3 MIN GAME · DRESS FOR THE COLD RELAY

"One, two, three — eyes on me!" The scarf, hat and glove go on a mat at the far end of the room. Two lines, or one line racing the song.

TEACHER "Run... put **one** thing on... run back... and give it to your friend!"

Each child runs, puts on **one** item, runs back, hands it over. "**Cold!**" **BIGS**, as they hand it on: "**It is cold. Put your hat on!**"

Then the sort: the two signs (**Autumn** and **Summer**) go down at either end of the circle, and the cards come out one at a time.

Sandals — which end? Woolly hat — which end?

The sorting cards from page 14 go straight onto the shelf after this, still warm from the game. What they sorted standing up in the circle, they will do again kneeling at a mat — that is the whole trick of this week.

1 MIN CLOSE

Everybody hugging themselves and shivering, voices growing. Whisper → normal → shout:

EVERYONE "Fall... cold... CLIMB! Happy AUTUMN!" (*flutter down · shiver · hands pull up a ladder · both arms fly open*)

Got 3 spare minutes? *The Mitten* (Jan Brett) — one lost mitten in the snow and every animal climbs inside. They will predict who comes next by the third page.

♪ **TODAY'S SONG MOMENT · DOWN, DOWN, DOWN THE LEAVES COME** chorus → Wednesday's verse → chorus

CHORUS

C Down, down, down the **F** leaves come **C** down, (*both hands flutter to the floor*)

F The tree is bare and the **C** field is **G7** brown! **C** (*arms up bare, then sweep low*)

Am Cold on my nose and **F** cold on my **C** toes, (*touch nose, touch toes*)

F That's how the **C** autumn **G7** goes! **C** (*big shrug, both hands out*)

WEDNESDAY · COLD

C Hat on my head and a scarf round me, (*hands on head, wind a scarf*)

G7 Brrr, it's cold — **C** as cold can be! (*whole-body shiver*)

Sing it once sitting and once standing with the real scarf being passed from child to child on the beat. Whoever is holding it at "Brrr" does the biggest shiver.

THURSDAY

Harvest · The Autumn Basket

Today's words: **harvest** (*tree · fall · cold come back*)

Grab: the **harvest basket** in the Magic Box — corn, a sweet potato, chestnuts chestnut and a persimmon; a cloth to cover the basket for the game; a chrysanthemum and the chrysanthemum card.

2 MIN MAGIC BOX HOOK

The box is **heavy** today. Ask two children to lift it together, and let them fail once.

EVERYONE "What's in the box? What's in the box?"

Shake it — a solid, dull thud, nothing rattles. Sniff it — it smells sweet and earthy.

TEACHER "Something **heavy**. Something you can **eat**..." (*lift the whole basket out with both arms, slowly, like it weighs a ton*)

Both arms out as if carrying a full basket. **"Harvest!"**

4 MIN TEACH · HARVEST

One thing at a time, right round the circle. Everybody holds it, feels the weight, says the word.

Corn — bumpy rows! (*run a thumb down the cob*)

Sweet potato — heavy and dusty. (*two hands, feel the weight*)

Chestnut — hard and shiny! (*tap it on the floor, tock tock*)

Persimmon — soft... careful. (*cup it in both palms, very gently*)

LITTLES name the food or just say the week word: **"Harvest!"** **BIGS** **"The field gives us food."** and **"The persimmon is soft."**

Then the counting: how many chestnuts? Lay them in a line and count together. Put them back in the basket one at a time and count down again.

Teacher fails: take an enormous bite out of the **raw sweet potato**. Chew. Beam. "Mmm! Delicious!" Offer it round. Wait for the outrage.

The **chrysanthemum** card and the real **chrysanthemum** go down beside the basket. The chrysanthemum is the flower that opens just as everything else is finishing — and it is waiting for tomorrow, when we hold our Double Ninth Festival (the festival itself falls on Sunday 18 October).

3 MIN GAME · FEEL THE HARVEST

"One, two, three — eyes on me!" The cloth goes over the basket. Nobody looks in again.

TEACHER "Hand in... no peeking... **name it before you pull it out!**" (*eyes up at the ceiling, hand under the cloth*)

Narrate your own turn first: "Ooh... it's **bumpy**... it's got little rows... it's CORN!" Out it comes.

"Corn!" **BIGS** **"I have the sweet potato. It is heavy."**

Every child gets a turn — about eight seconds each. Right or wrong, everybody claps: the basket is its own **control of error**, you pull it out and you see.

Put the persimmon in last, and warn them it is soft before the first hand goes in. One squashed persimmon is a good story; four is a floor to mop.

1 MIN CLOSE

Arms out as if carrying a heavy basket, voices growing. Whisper → normal → shout:

EVERYONE "Fall... cold... CLIMB! Happy AUTUMN!" (*flutter down · shiver · hands pull up a ladder · both arms fly open*)

Got 3 spare minutes? *The Little Red Hen* — a whole harvest from seed to bread, and nobody helps. They will be furious on her behalf, which is exactly right.

♪ **TODAY'S SONG MOMENT · DOWN, DOWN, DOWN THE LEAVES COME** chorus → Thursday's verse → chorus

CHORUS

C Down, down, down the **F** leaves come **C** down, (*both hands flutter to the floor*)

F The tree is bare and the **C** field is **G7** brown! **C** (*arms up bare, then sweep low*)

Am Cold on my nose and **F** cold on my **C** toes, (*touch nose, touch toes*)

F That's how the **C** autumn **G7** goes! **C** (*big shrug, both hands out*)

THURSDAY · HARVEST

Am Corn and chestnuts, sweet and gold, (*both hands out, cupped and full*)

G7 The autumn field **C** gives all it holds! (*big low sweep, arms open wide*)

Sing this one with the basket in the middle of the circle. On "gives all it holds" everybody's arms open outward — away from themselves, not towards. Tomorrow they give the cake away; this is where that starts.

FRIDAY

Climb climbing high + Big Review

Today's words: **tree · fall · cold · harvest · climb** — the whole week

Grab: Double Ninth cake (or any steamed cake) wrapped up, a **chrysanthemum** and a walking stick; every prop from the week back in the box (the two twigs, the leaf basket, the scarf, the harvest basket); Wang Wei's poem printed big; the awards (print pack page 17); the tall card; coats on — we are going outside.

2 MIN MAGIC BOX HOOK

The box comes out full, heavy, rustling, and smelling faintly of cake.

TEACHER "Today the box has the **WHOLE WEEK** in it. What's this?"

Pull the props out one at a time and hold each one up in silence — they will supply the word before you can open your mouth.

Bare twig → **"Tree!"** A handful of leaves, dropped → **"Fall!"** Scarf → **"Cold!"** Corn → **"Harvest!"**

Last of all, the walking stick and the cake. Everyone waits. Hands pull up a ladder. **"CLIMB!"**

4 MIN TEACH · CLIMB, THEN THE WHOLE WEEK

Everybody stands. We tell the whole week with our bodies, twice — slow, then fast:

A tall, tall **TREE!** (*arms up wide and high*)

The leaves **FALL** down! (*flutter all ten fingers to the floor*)

Brr — it's **COLD!** (*hug yourself and shiver*)

The **HARVEST** is in! (*both arms out, carrying a full basket*)

Up we **CLIMB!** (*both hands pulling up a ladder, higher and higher*)

Then coats on, and out. Climb the steps, or the little hill, or the slope by the gate — whatever you have. At the top, everybody stops and **looks out** at everything. Out of breath is the right way to arrive.

Read **"Thinking of My Brothers on the Double Ninth"**, by Wang Wei up there: *"Alone, a stranger in a far-off land, at every festival I miss my family twice as much. I know my brothers are climbing high today, and one of them is missing."* Then ask, quietly: **who do you miss?** Who do you wish were here with us?

Teacher fails: set off **down** the steps announcing "Up we go! Up, up, UP!" Keep going down, cheerfully. Wait to be turned round.

The **tall** card completes the row: tree · autumn · cold · chrysanthemum · tall. Point along it and let them tell you what each one was.

3 MIN GAME · CLIMBING HIGH — CLIMB HIGH, THEN GIVE THE CAKE AWAY

The climb is the game. Up together, look out together, and come down together holding the rail.

TEACHER "The cake is not for us. Who is it for?" (*hold up the wrapped Double Ninth cake*)

At the bottom, unwrap it — and then **don't** eat it. Every child carries a piece to the grandparents at the gate. **"For you!"** **BIGS**
"Happy Double Ninth Festival! This is for you."

If the weather is against you, climb the indoor stairs to the top landing and look out of the highest window you have. It still counts. The cake still goes to the gate.

Double Ninth Festival is also **Seniors' Day**, Elders' Day. Giving the cake away instead of eating it is the whole festival in one thirty-second act — don't explain it, just do it and let them feel it.

1 MIN CLOSE + AWARDS

Every child gets a "You are a STAR!" award to take home with a leaf from the basket. Then, standing, with all five gestures:

EVERYONE "Fall... cold... CLIMB! Happy AUTUMN!" (*flutter down · shiver · hands pull up a ladder · both arms fly open on the shout*)

Got 3 spare minutes? *We're Going on a Bear Hunt* (Michael Rosen) — a whole-body chant about going over and under and up. Do it with the actions, standing, after a week of climbing.

♪ **TODAY'S SONG MOMENT · DOWN, DOWN, DOWN THE LEAVES COME** Friday's verse, then the **WHOLE** song, top to bottom

CHORUS

C Down, down, down the **F** leaves come **C** down, (*both hands flutter to the floor*)

F The tree is bare and the **C** field is **G7** brown! **C** (*arms up bare, then sweep low*)

Am Cold on my nose and **F** cold on my **C** toes, (*touch nose, touch toes*)

F That's how the **C** autumn **G7** goes! **C** (*big shrug, both hands out*)

FRIDAY · CLIMB

C Up we go, up so high, (*climb an imaginary ladder*)

G7 Look at the world — **C** and wave goodbye! (*shade your eyes, look out, wave big*)

The finale: chorus → Monday, Tuesday, Wednesday, Thursday, Friday → chorus, sung **at the top of the climb** with the Double Ninth cake waiting at the bottom. They learned it one verse a morning without noticing, and this run-through **is** the review of the whole week.

★ Down, Down, Down the Leaves Come

Week 8 theme song
C (0003) · F (2010) · G7 (0212) · Am (2000)

The one song of the week — sung at every circle. Same chorus daily, one new verse each morning, full song on Friday.

CHORUS — SING IT EVERY SINGLE DAY

- C** Down, down, down the **F** leaves come **C** down, *(both hands flutter to the floor)*
F The tree is bare and the **C** field is **G7** brown! **C** *(arms up bare, then sweep low)*
Am Cold on my nose and **F** cold on my **C** toes, *(touch nose, touch toes)*
F That's how the **C** autumn **G7** goes! **C** *(big shrug, both hands out)*

MONDAY · TREE

- C** A tall, tall tree with a hundred leaves, *(arms up, fingers wiggling)*
G7 One by one — **C** the autumn takes! *(fingers fold away one at a time)*

TUESDAY · FALL

- C** Fall, leaf, fall — spin and sway, *(turn slowly, arms loose)*
G7 Down to the ground **C** you go today! *(sink to the floor and go still)*

WEDNESDAY · COLD

- C** Hat on my head and a scarf round me, *(hands on head, wind a scarf)*
G7 Brrr, it's cold — **C** as cold can be! *(whole-body shiver)*

THURSDAY · HARVEST

- Am** Corn and chestnuts, sweet and gold, *(both hands out, cupped and full)*
G7 The autumn field **C** gives all it holds! *(big low sweep, arms open wide)*

FRIDAY · CLIMB

- C** Up we go, up so high, *(climb an imaginary ladder)*
G7 Look at the world — **C** and wave goodbye! *(shade your eyes, look out, wave big)*

Strum: Down · Down · Down-Up (“leaves — come — down-a”).

Can't manage it yet? Four slow downs per bar works fine — the kids only hear the fun.

Practice this loop for five minutes tonight: **C** (4 strums) → **F** (4 strums) → **C** → **G7** → **C**. Add **Am** last: it is one finger on the same string as F, so slide from Am to F and back until it stops feeling like a change. That's the entire song — and four of the five verses are only C and G7. If your fingers get stuck, put the uke down and do the finger-play instead: the class will not notice, and the actions carry the meaning either way.